

CASTE MATTERS
BJP supporters protest demanding OBC quota in Mumbai, June 26, 2021

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MAHARASHTRA

COUNTING CASTE

By Dhaval S. Kulkarni

A running joke among the more cynical observers of Maharashtra politics is that if the numbers of every caste and social group as claimed by caste-based organisations are added up, the state's population may exceed its present figure of around 125 million several times over. There has been no scientific headcount of caste numbers since the British era, and the lack of authentic empirical data has led to a situation where caste groups and their leaders routinely make vociferous demands based on self-ascribed numbers that everyone else sees as exaggerated.

At present, only data on the Scheduled Castes and Tribes (SC/ ST) is collected in the decadal census. But if Other Backward Class (OBC) leaders have their way, that state of affairs could change. After Bihar launched its own caste census on January 7, political parties and social groups in Maharashtra have revived their long-standing demand for a similar exercise to be conducted here.

Former minister and senior NCP leader Chhagan Bhujbal has set the ball rolling by writing to Chief Minister Eknath Shinde and deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis seeking a caste census on the lines of that in Bihar. Bhujbal, who belongs to the OBC Mali (gardener) community, has pointed out that OBCs and denotified and nomadic tribes could not be provided development programmes and adequate budgetary support due to the lack of scientific figures about them. Former deputy CM Ajit Pawar of the NCP, Nana Patole, president, Maharashtra Pradesh Congress Committee, and Prakash Ambedkar, the grandson of Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar and chief of the Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi, have also supported the demand. It suits some of these parties to ply this line presently, but if a caste census materialises, it is sure to stir the pot in many unpredictable ways.

Marathas, whose own modest caste origins were later obscured by 'Kshatriyaisation' in the post-Shivaji era, dominate state politics. But the OBCs—spread across religions, classes and castes—are

OVER THE YEARS

- In independent India, data about only SCs and STs was collected in the census. However, a headcount of backward class groups was recommended by the Kakasaheb Kalelkar (1955) and B.P. Mandal (1980) commissions
- During Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi rule, the assembly unanimously approved a Jan. 8, 2020 resolution seeking caste-based census. However, the Centre has refused to enumerate caste-wise populations other than SC and ST in the much-delayed 2021 census
- OBCs are estimated to be around 53 per cent of Maharashtra's population (43.7 per cent Hindus and 8.4 per cent non-Hindus)
- The Maratha-Kunbis are claimed to be around a third of the state's population and thus the largest caste cluster. They are recognised as OBCs.